

WHEN IS THE NAME GIVEN?

A boy receives his name at the ceremony of his Brit (circumcision), (while a girl is named at a Synagogue during a service when the Torah is read).

Tradition has it that parents receive “divine inspiration” in selecting names for their children, Thus whatever Jewish name is chosen, it is surely the right one for that particular boy or girl.

A name helps establish a bond between a child and the heritage of his/her people. It should be selected from among the vast treasure house of Hebrew names in the Torah and Talmud, or from the traditional Yiddish names, which have been bestowed upon Jewish children for generations.

According to Chassidic teachings, a person's name is closely connected to the essence of his soul and as such, is a pathway to his inner psyche.

DIFFERENT TRADITIONS

Among Ashkenazic Jews it is the custom to name one's son or daughter after a beloved, departed relative whose life was an inspiration to all and whose qualities the parents would like to see reborn and emulated in their child. Sephardic Jews often name their children after an honored grandparent or other relative who is still living. Another widespread custom is to give a child the name of a great Torah personality, thus forming a spiritual tie between the two.

A NOBLE PURPOSE

By bringing a child into the covenant in the proper way we are giving him an excellent start. Circumcision is the eternal symbol of the Jew's willingness to subjugate the desires of his physical body to the will of G-d. It is meant to elevate him to the level of a G-d-loving, G-d-fearing human being – one who places morality above the yearnings of the flesh. Through Brit Milah a boy identifies as a Jew at the source of life, forever linked to the source

ב"ה

BRIT MILAH

TRADITIONS & CUSTOMS

**THANK YOU FOR JOINING US
AT THE BRIS OF OUR NEWBORN SON.**

RABBI YITZCHOK & NECHAMA DINA BERGSTEIN

FRIDAY, 6 NISSAN, 5765 - APRIL 15, 2005

When the child is brought into the synagogue, those present say:
ברוך Blessed be he who has entered.

The *mohel* then says the following:

אשרי Happy is the man You choose and bring near to dwell in Your courtyards; we will be satiated with the goodness of Your House, Your holy Temple.¹ The Lord spoke to Moses, saying: Pinchas, the son of Elazar, the son of Aaron the Kohen, has turned My wrath away from the Children of Israel when he displayed anger among them in My behalf, so that I did not wipe out the Children of Israel in My anger. Therefore say: I grant him My covenant of peace.²

When the child is placed on the Seat of Elijah, the *mohel* says:

זה This is the Seat of Elijah, may he be remembered for good. For Your deliverance I hope, O Lord.³ I have hoped for Your deliverance, Lord, and I have performed Your commandments.⁴ Elijah, angel of the Covenant, here is yours before you; stand at my right and support me. I rejoice in Your word, like one who finds great spoil.⁵ Those who love Your Torah have abounding peace, and there is no stumbling for them.⁶ Happy is the man You choose and bring near to dwell in Your courtyards; we will be satiated with the goodness of Your House, Your holy Temple.¹

The *mohel* recites the following blessing. All present respond Amen as indicated.

ברוך Blessed are You, Lord our God, King of the universe, who has sanctified us with His commandments and commanded us concerning circumcision. (Amen)

The father of the child recites the following blessing between the *milah* and the *periah*:

ברוך Blessed are You, Lord our God, King of the universe, who has sanctified us with His commandments and commanded us to enter him into the Covenant of Abraham our father.

Those present respond:

אמן Amen. Just as he has entered into the Covenant, so may he enter into Torah, into marriage, and into good deeds.

After the *chituch* has been properly done, the *mohel* should quickly do the *periah* and the *metzitzah*. A cup of wine is handed to one of those present, who is honored with reciting the following:

ברוך Blessed are You, Lord our God, King of the universe, who creates the fruit of the vine.

But whenever a Brit is held, it is a very special occasion, and at the appointed time family and friends joyfully gather. In the presence of a Minyan if possible, the child is ushered into the covenant of Abraham. Each step of the ceremony is remembered for life; each memory is savored forever.

We do not invite people to a Brit; we simply inform them of the time and place. Why? Because it would be improper for them to decline an invitation to an event where Elijah the prophet is present.

ELIJAH THE PROPHET

At every Brit Milah Elijah the Prophet is an honored guest. Long ago when a king of Israel, under treacherous influences, abolished circumcision, Elijah cried out to G-d that Israel had forsaken His precious covenant. G-d thereupon instructed him to be present and witness all circumcisions.

THE MOHEL

Although the Torah obligates a father to circumcise his son, the Brit is generally performed by a Mohel because most fathers are not qualified to perform the ceremony. The man chosen to perform the Brit Milah should be traditional and G-d-fearing, whose skill has been finely honed.

SANDIK, KVATER AND OTHER HONORS

In addition to the Mohel, the Sandik, who holds the child during the circumcision, should be a person held in great esteem by the family and the community. The day of the Brit is regarded as a holiday for the Sandik, just as for the father and the Mohel. Usually a married or engaged couple is chosen to serve as Kvater, those who bring the child to the room where the Brit is held. The woman takes the child from his mother's arms and in turn hands him to the man who brings the child into the room. He or another man then places the child on the special chair designated for Elijah. Subsequently the father places his son on the lap of the Sandik. After the Mohel performs the circumcision two other gentlemen may be given honors – one to hold the child while the second recites the special blessing and prayer for naming the child.

BRIT MILAH – CIRCUMCISION

“Every male among you shall be circumcised... it shall be a sign of the covenant between Me and you. He that is eight days old among you shall be circumcised”. Genesis 17:10-12

The performance of Brit Milah (circumcision) is one of the most sacred rituals in Jewish life. Brit Milah is the tie that forever binds a Jewish boy to his Creator. It is the special sign that has distinguished the Jew from among the nations ever since our father Abraham circumcised himself and his household – at G-d's command – when he was ninety-nine years old.

When Ishmael, Abraham's son, entered into the covenant, the boy had already reached the age of thirteen – fully capable of understanding the divine command. He was proud of his decision to rationally submit to G-d's command, but his acceptance of Brit Milah was limited to his reason. Isaac, on the other hand, who was born a year after G-d commanded Abraham to perform this rite, was circumcised when he was just eight days old, an infant with no understanding whatsoever.

A Jew is commanded to circumcise his son on the eighth day after his birth, when his faculty of reason is not yet developed. This aspect signifies that a Jew is bound and committed to G-d at the earliest opportunity possible in an absolute and all-comprehensive way, which transcends his reason and perception.

THE DAY

The Brit is performed on the eighth day following the child's birth. For example if a child is born on Sunday (from Saturday sunset through Sunday sunset) the Brit is held the following Sunday. This applies even if the eighth day occurs on Shabbat or a major festival (providing the birth is not by caesarian section). If however, the Mohel decides that the child is physically unfit to undergo circumcision at the prescribed time, because he is jaundiced or otherwise unwell, the Brit is postponed. Once delayed, the ceremony cannot be held on a Shabbat or festival, but takes place at the first opportunity on any other day.

ORDER OF A CIRCUMCISION

When the child is brought into the synagogue, those present say:

בְּרוּךְ הַבּא:

The *mohel* then says the following:

**אֲשֶׁרִי תִבְחַר וּתְקַרֵב יִשְׁכֵּן חֲצֵרֶיךָ, נִשְׁבְּעָה בְּטוֹב בִּיתְךָ קֹדֶשׁ
הַיְכָלְךָ: וַיִּדְבֵּר יי אֶל מֹשֶׁה לֵאמֹר: פִּינָחֵם בֶּן אֶלְעָזָר
בֶּן אֶהֱרֹן הַכֹּהֵן הַשֵּׁבִי אֶת חֲמַתִּי מֵעַל בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל בְּקִנְאוֹ אֶת
קִנְאָתִי בְּתוֹכָם, וְלֹא כָלִיתִי אֶת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל בְּקִנְאָתִי: לָכֵן אָמַר,
הֲנִי נִתֵּן לֹא אֶת בְּרִיתִי שְׁלוֹם:**

When the child is placed on the Seat of Elijah, the *mohel* says:

**זֶה הַכֶּסֶּא שֶׁל אֱלֹהֵינוּ זְכוֹר לְטוֹב: לִישׁוּעָתְךָ קִוִּיתִי יי:³
שִׁבְרָתִי לִישׁוּעָתְךָ יי, וּמִצּוֹתֶיךָ עָשִׂיתִי:⁴ אֱלֹהֵינוּ מִלֵּאד
הַבְּרִית, הִנֵּה שָׁלָךְ לִפְנֶיךָ, עֲמוּד עַל יְמִינִי וְסִמְכֵנִי: שֵׁשׁ אֲנֹכִי
עַל אֲמָרְתְּךָ, בְּמוֹצֵא שָׁלָל רָב:⁵ שְׁלוֹם רַב לְאֶהֱבֵי תוֹרְתְךָ,
וְאֵין לָמוֹ מִבְּשׂוֹל:⁶ אֲשֶׁרִי תִבְחַר וּתְקַרֵב יִשְׁכֵּן חֲצֵרֶיךָ, נִשְׁבְּעָה
בְּטוֹב בִּיתְךָ, קֹדֶשׁ הַיְכָלְךָ:**

The *mohel* recites the following blessing. All present respond *אמן* as indicated.

**בְּרוּךְ אַתָּה יי אֱלֹהֵינוּ מֶלֶךְ הָעוֹלָם, אֲשֶׁר קִדְּשָׁנוּ בְּמִצְוֹתָיו,
וְצִוָּנוּ עַל הַמִּילָה: (אָמֵן)**

The father of the child recites the following blessing between the *milah* and the *periah*:

**בְּרוּךְ אַתָּה יי אֱלֹהֵינוּ מֶלֶךְ הָעוֹלָם, אֲשֶׁר קִדְּשָׁנוּ בְּמִצְוֹתָיו,
וְצִוָּנוּ לְהַכְנִיסוֹ בְּבְרִיתוֹ שֶׁל אֲבִרָהּ אֲבִינוּ:**

Those present respond:

**אָמֵן. בְּשֵׁם שְׁנֵכֶנָם לְבְרִית, בֶּן יִכְנֹס לְתוֹרָה וּלְחֻפָּה
וּלְמַעֲשֵׂים טוֹבִים:**

After the *chituch* has been properly done, the *mohel* should quickly do the *periah* and the *metzitzah*. A cup of wine is handed to one of those present, who is honored with reciting the following:

בְּרוּךְ אַתָּה יי אֱלֹהֵינוּ מֶלֶךְ הָעוֹלָם, בּוֹרֵא פְּרִי הַגֶּפֶן: (אָמֵן)

בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה יי אֱלֹהֵינוּ מֶלֶךְ הָעוֹלָם, אֲשֶׁר קִדַּשׁ יְדִיד מִבֶּטֶן,
וְחֹק בְּשָׂארוֹ שֵׁם, וַצִּיָּצְאוּ חֲתָם בְּרִית קֹדֶשׁ, עַל
בֶּן בְּשֶׁכֶר זֹאת, אֵל חַי חֲלָקְנוּ צוּרְנוּ צִוָּה לְהַצִּיל יְדִידוֹת שְׂאֲרֵנוּ
מִשַּׁחַת, לְמַעַן בְּרִיתוֹ אֲשֶׁר שֵׁם בְּבִשְׂרֵנוּ: בָּרוּךְ אַתָּה יי, בּוֹרֵת
הַבְּרִית: (אָמֵן)

The words in bold are recited aloud by those present followed by the reader.

אֱלֹהֵינוּ וְאֱלֹהֵי אֲבוֹתֵינוּ, קִים אֶת הַיָּלֵד הַזֶּה לְאָבִיו וּלְאִמּוֹ, וְיִקְרָא
שְׁמוֹ בִּישְׂרָאֵל (Say the child's name) בֶּן (Say the father's name), יִשְׁמַח
הָאֵב בְּיוֹצֵא חֲלָצוֹ וְתִגַּל אִמּוֹ בְּפָרִי כְּטָנָה, בְּכַתּוּב: יִשְׂמַח אָבִיד וְאִמּוֹ,
וְתִגַּל יוֹלְדָתוֹ: ² וְנֹאמַר: וְאֶעֱבֹר עָלֶיךָ וְאֶרְאֶה מִתְּבוֹסֶסֶת בְּדַמְיֶךָ,
וְאֹמַר לְךָ בְּדַמְיֶךָ חַי, וְאֹמַר לְךָ בְּדַמְיֶךָ חַי: ³ וְנֹאמַר: זָכַר לְעוֹלָם
בְּרִיתוֹ, דָּבָר צִוָּה לְאַלֶּף דּוֹד: אֲשֶׁר בָּרַת אֶת אֲבִרָהָם, וְשִׁבְעָתוֹ לְיִשְׁחָק:
וַיַּעֲמִידָהּ לְעֵשֶׂק לְחָק, לְיִשְׂרָאֵל בְּרִית עוֹלָם: ⁴ וְנֹאמַר: וַיִּמָּל אֲבִרָהָם
אֶת יִצְחָק בְּנוֹ בֶּן שְׁמֹנֶת יָמִים, כְּאֲשֶׁר צִוָּה אֱלֹהִים: ⁵ הוֹדּוּ לַיי
כִּי טוֹב, כִּי לְעוֹלָם חֶסֶד: הוֹדּוּ לַיי כִּי טוֹב, כִּי לְעוֹלָם חֶסֶד: ⁶
(Say the child's name) זֶה הַקָּטָן גָּדוֹל יְהִי, בְּשֵׁם שְׁנֹכְנֵם לְבְרִית, בֶּן
יָבֵנִים לְתוֹרָה וּלְחֻפָּה וּלְמַעֲשִׂים טוֹבִים:

A child is given to drink the wine over which the blessing has been made, or the one who recited the blessing drinks it himself.

After the circumcision, the *mohel* and the father of the infant recite the following prayer:

רְבוּנוֹ שֶׁל עוֹלָם, יְהִי רָצוֹן מִלְּפָנֶיךָ שְׁיֵהָא זֶה חָשׁוּב וּמִקְבָּל לְפָנֶיךָ
כְּאֵלּוֹ הַקְּרִבְתִּיהוּ לְפָנֶי כֶּסֶף כְּבוֹדְךָ, וְאַתָּה בְּרַחֲמֶיךָ
הַרְבִּים שְׁלַח עַל יְדֵי מַלְאָכֶיךָ הַקְּדוֹשִׁים נִשְׁמָה קְדוֹשָׁה וּמְהוּרָה

Mohel:

Father:

לְ (child's name) בֶּן (father's name)

לְבָנִי (child's name)

הַנִּמּוֹל עֲתָה לְשִׁמְךָ הַגָּדוֹל, וְשִׁיְהִיָּה לְבוֹ פְתוּחַ בְּפִתְחוֹ שֶׁל אוֹלָם
בְּתוֹרָתְךָ הַקְּדוֹשָׁה, לְלִמּוּד וּלְלִמּוּד לְשִׁמּוֹר וּלְעִשׂוֹת, וְתֵן לוֹ אֲרִיכוֹת
יָמִים וְשָׁנִים, חַיִּים שֶׁל יְרֵאת חֲטָא, חַיִּים שֶׁל עֲשָׂר וְכְבוֹד,
וְשִׁתְּמִילָא מִשְׁאֲלוֹת לְבוֹ לְטוֹבָה, אָמֵן וְכֵן יְהִי רָצוֹן:

ברוך Blessed are You, Lord our God, King of the universe, who sanctified the beloved one¹ from the womb, set His statute in his flesh, and sealed his descendants with the sign of the holy Covenant. Therefore, as a reward of this [circumcision], the living God, our Portion, our Rock, has ordained that the beloved of our flesh be saved from the abyss, for the sake of the Covenant which He has set in our flesh. Blessed are You Lord, who makes the Covenant.

The words in bold are recited aloud by those present followed by the reader.

אלהינו Our God and God of our fathers, preserve this child for his father and mother, and his name in Israel shall be called (Say the child's name) the son of (Say his father's name). May the father rejoice in his offspring, and his mother be glad with the fruit of her womb, as it is written: May your father and mother rejoice, and she who bore you be glad.² And it is said: I passed by you and saw you weltering in your blood, and I said to you: You shall live through your blood; and I said to you: You shall live through your blood.³ And it is said: He has remembered His Covenant forever, the word which He has commanded to a thousand generations; the Covenant which He made with Abraham, and His oath to Isaac; He established it for Jacob as a statute, for Israel as an everlasting Covenant.⁴ And it is said: Abraham circumcised his son Isaac when he was eight days old, as God had commanded him.⁵ Give thanks to the Lord for He is good, for His kindness is everlasting. Give thanks to the Lord for He is good, for His kindness is everlasting.⁶ May this little infant (Say the child's name) become great. Just as he has entered the Covenant, so may he enter into Torah, into marriage, and into good deeds.

A child is given to drink the wine over which the blessing has been made, or the one who recited the blessing drinks it himself.

After the circumcision, the *mohel* and the father of the infant recite the following prayer:

רבונו Sovereign of the universe, may it be Your will that this [circumcision] be regarded and accepted by You as if I had offered him before the Throne of Your Glory. And You, in Your abounding mercy, send through Your holy angels a holy and pure soul to

Father:

Mohel:

my son (child's name)

(child's name) the son of
(father's name)

who has now been circumcised for the sake of Your great Name. May his heart be open as the portal of the *ulam* in the Temple in Your holy Torah, to learn and to teach, to observe and to practice; grant him long life, a life imbued with the fear of sin, a life of wealth and honor; and fulfill the desires of his heart for good. Amen, and so may it be Your will.